

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

(a) "Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss. [10 marks]

Model answer (184 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The statement joins a defensible claim to a question-begging one. Complete liberty does tend to generate inequality; that order and restriction imply a necessary loss of freedom is true on one conception of liberty and false on another. Limb one - complete liberty and inequality. Unrestricted freedom of contract, property accumulation and market power let the strong dominate the weak, and Rousseau supplies the mechanism: convention converts difference into durable dependence. Limb two - the hidden premise. "A necessary loss of freedom" presupposes the negative conception, on which every law is *prima facie* a subtraction from liberty. On the republican conception (Pettit, 1997), law that tracks the avowable interests of the governed and remains publicly contestable constitutes freedom, because it strips private persons of arbitrary power. "Necessary" is doing illegitimate work. The reframing. The limbs are therefore in tension: if unregulated liberty produces dependence, and dependence is unfreedom, well-designed restriction can increase aggregate freedom. The concession. Not every restriction is of the right kind. Arbitrary or perfectionist regulation does subtract freedom, and Berlin's warning about coercion imposed for a citizen's "real self" remains apposite. Verdict.

(b) "Nationalisation is not socialisation." Comment. [10 marks]

Model answer (198 words; practice model, not official): Claim. The statement is correct, and it identifies the single most useful control in the socialist family. The distinction. Nationalisation transfers ownership of productive assets to the organs of the state. Socialisation requires that productive property and economic power be subject to social control - control exercised by society through democratic and participatory institutions. Why transfer of title is insufficient. Ownership answers the question who holds the asset; socialism's question is who decides about investment, production, pace and purpose. A ministry-run monopoly may answer the first without altering the second, in which case the worker exchanges a private superior for an official one and the standing subjection remains. The named objection this meets. State ownership can become ownership by officials - the bureaucratic-domination objection. The reply is that socialism requires democratic control, workplace participation and accountability, and that nationalisation alone is not socialisation. Evidence from the family. Guild socialism is the cleanest illustration, since it opposes private capitalism and bureaucratic statism simultaneously; market socialism makes the same point from the other side, separating markets from capitalist ownership. Qualification. Verdict. Nationalisation is at most an instrument of socialisation and is never identical with it; the philosophical question is control, not title.

(c) Can gender equality be realised within a socialist regime? Analyse. [10 marks]

Model answer (199 words; practice model, not official): What the stem presupposes. The question tests the Marxist feminist diagnosis: women's subordination arises with private property and class society and is functional to the property-owning family. The prediction. Abolish private property, socialise domestic labour, draw women into social production, and the material basis of subordination is removed. What the prediction gets right. The property and inheritance mechanism is real; economic dependence is a genuine lever; and participation in social production does alter bargaining power. The defeater. Male dominance is observable across societies with radically different modes of production, and it persisted where private property in the means of production was abolished. That is the evidence advanced for patriarchy's autonomy. The residue the diagnosis cannot reach. Social reproduction: who performs the unpaid care, who decides about the body, who holds authority inside the household, and who is subject to violence and stigma. Socialist feminism widens the analysis to exactly this - two systems, each with its own logic, historically entangled and neither reducible to the other. Verdict. A socialist regime removes one structural condition and is therefore necessary on the material axis. It is not sufficient unless it also transforms the sexual division of labour, the family, sexuality and care.

(d) Present a brief account of origin and development of Social Contract Theory. [10 marks]

Model answer (194 words; practice model, not official): Origin. Social contract theory explains the origin and justification of the state through an agreement, actual or hypothetical, among individuals. Its founding achievement is to derive political obligation from the standpoint of individuals rather than from divine right or conquest. Hobbes. From a state of nature marked by insecurity, fear and conflict, the contract secures peace through a broad and irreversible transfer of judgment to a strong sovereign. Rights are surrendered extensively for the sake of self-preservation. Locke - the first development. The state of nature becomes more norm-governed, containing inconveniences rather than war. The arrangement becomes a fiduciary trust for the impartial protection of rights already held, so government is limited, natural rights are retained, and violation of the trust justifies resistance. Rousseau - the second development. Freedom in the state of nature has been corrupted by inequality, and the contract's purpose becomes collective self-rule. Sovereignty stays with the people as the general will, so obedience becomes self-legislation and civil freedom is moral autonomy. The fiction objection, answered. No actual historical contract occurred. The theory's value is normative rather than

historical: it asks what terms of rule free and equal persons could reasonably accept. Verdict.

(e) "Genocide is simply mass murder on a large scale." Comment. [10 marks]

Model answer (186 words; practice model, not official): Position. False - and its falsity is why the concept exists. What the concept adds. Under the Genocide Convention (1948), genocide is specified acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group, as such. The defining element is intent against the group, not the toll. Lemkin's conception. Lemkin, who coined the term in *Axis Rule in Occupied Europe* (1944), did not define genocide as mass killing. He conceived it as a coordinated plan of different actions destroying the essential foundations of a group's life - institutions, culture, language, religion, economy, security, liberty, health, dignity - killing being one method among several. Why the wrong is irreducible. A group's existence is sustained by its institutions, language and transmission as well as by its members' lives, so those foundations can be destroyed even where many members survive. Losing a form of shared life is not captured by counting murders. Two qualifications. The Convention is narrower than Lemkin and omits political groups. Its presupposition - that groups have a morally significant existence not exhausted by members' interests - needs argument, since individualists deny it. Verdict.

Q2

(a) "Formal equality is either empty or ideological." Assess this claim with reference to Mill and Marx. [20 marks]

Model answer (399 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The claim is half right. Formal equality is neither empty nor merely ideological, but it is insufficient, and Mill and Marx diagnose its insufficiency at two different depths. What formal equality actually secures. Equality before the law and equal protection of the laws establish the rule against legal privilege by status, and this is a genuine achievement rather than a decorative one: without it, substantive measures lose the standard by which they can themselves be criticised. Its weakness is that it can be perfectly satisfied in a society that remains radically unequal - the objection that it can become paper equality. Mill's diagnosis - the social depth. Mill affirms equal moral standing and equality before the law, and then carries equality beyond formal rights into social relations. His central case is *The Subjection of Women* (1869), where the legal and social subordination of women is treated as a relic of domination; the appeal to women's "nature" is disqualified as evidence because that nature has been socially manufactured through subjection. But his remedy stops at reform of property and labour conditions and refuses coercive equalisation, because the aim of removing hierarchy is to release individuality, not to impose uniformity. Marx's diagnosis - the material depth. Marx holds that formally equal exchange can conceal material exploitation: the wage contract appears free and equal between legal equals while class power shapes production and appropriation. Hence an equal right can be a right of inequality, because a common standard applied to persons differing in need, burden and starting position guarantees unequal effect. The corrective is equity - differentiated treatment answering to actual condition - expressed in the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* formula, "from each according to his ability, to each according to his need". The formula is indexed to a higher stage of social cooperation and is not a market-time salary rule. Adjudication. Mill shows that formal equality is socially incomplete; Marx shows that it may be structurally complicit. The second is the stronger charge and the more speculative, since the two-stage structure is a normative projection rather than a demonstrated law. Neither thinker establishes that formal equality is empty: both rely on it when identifying the subordination and the exploitation they condemn. Verdict. Formal equality is a necessary and insufficient condition of equality proper - indispensable as a constraint, misleading as a completed ideal, and ideological only when presented as the whole of what equality demands.

(b) "An un-interfered-with dependant is nevertheless unfree." Critically discuss this claim and its consequences for the relation between law and liberty. [15 marks]

Model answer (295 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The claim is correct and it reverses the standard account of law: if freedom is a secured standing rather than an event-count, then non-arbitrary law constitutes freedom instead of subtracting from it. The argument. The negative conception measures freedom by actual interference. Consider a person under a kind master, an indulgent husband or a benevolent ruler who happens not to interfere. She is not interfered with, so on the negative count she is free. Yet she must flatter, anticipate, self-censor and live at another's discretion, because the other retains the capacity to interfere arbitrarily and with impunity. That dependence is a real unfreedom an interference-count cannot register. Freedom is therefore best specified as non-domination (Pettit, 1997; historical recovery, Skinner, 1998). The controlling distinction. Interference is an act; domination is a standing capacity to interfere arbitrarily. Law that tracks the avowable interests of those it governs and remains publicly contestable can interfere without dominating; a master's forbearance can dominate without interfering. The consequence for law. On the negative view, every law is *prima facie* a subtraction from liberty. On the republican view, law of the right kind is freedom-constituting, because it strips private persons of arbitrary power. The Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, 1976 illustrates the form of such a remedy by attacking a relation of personal dependence. Enactment is not implementation. First objection and reply. Everything non-domination names could be redescribed as a high probability of future interference. But probability is contingent and can be low precisely where dependence is total; and the republican account additionally explains why the dependant's own conduct changes. Second objection and reply. Who decides which interferences are arbitrary? Republicans answer procedurally: interference is non-arbitrary when it tracks the avowable interests of the governed and remains open to contestation. Verdict.

(c) "The anarchist and the Marxist agree about domination and disagree about the state." Critically examine. [15 marks]

Model answer (289 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The statement is accurate about the disagreement and misleading about the agreement, and separating those two claims is the whole answer. Where they genuinely agree. Both hold that existing society is structured by domination rather than by mere inequality; both reject the view that formal legal freedom is sufficient; and both project an end-state in which the state as an instrument of class domination has ceased to be necessary. Where the agreement

is thinner than it looks. They do not agree about what domination is. Anarchism identifies authority and hierarchy as the primary domination, so the state is the paradigm case. Marxism identifies the class relation rooted in production, so the state is an effect whose abolition without transformation of property would leave capitalist power intact. The shared vocabulary conceals a difference in the explanandum. The disagreement about the state. Anarchism would abolish or supersede the state without transitional sovereignty, organising through federation, autonomy and voluntary association. Marxism has the working class exercise transitional political power through class organisation. Bakunin predicts that such a revolutionary state may create a new ruling stratum; Marxists reply that organised class power is required to defeat entrenched property and coercion, and that premature abolition is disarmament. Why the exchange is unresolved. Each side identifies a real danger created by the other's remedy. Retaining organisation concentrates power without a reliable mechanism of recall - the substitutionism problem. Abolishing it disperses power unaccountably, leaving expertise, status and economic strength ungoverned - the hidden-authority problem. Verdict. The agreement is about the fact of domination and not about its mechanism; the disagreement about the state follows from that deeper difference rather than standing beside it. Neither side has supplied an institutional answer to the danger the other names.

Q3

(a) "Every ideology in this clause is stronger as a diagnosis than as a remedy." Discuss with reference to anarchism, Marxism and socialism. [20 marks]

Model answer (390 words; practice model, not official): Provisional thesis. The proposition is true of all three, but for three different reasons, and the value of the claim lies entirely in specifying which residual defeats which remedy. Anarchism. The diagnosis is powerful: the state demands obedience because a command is legally authoritative rather than because it is right, and such a standing right subordinates one person's judgment to another's institutional will; Bakunin adds that concentrated power deforms both ruler and ruled. The remedy is weaker. Three objections can be relocated - the security dilemma by federated defence and restorative institutions, the scale objection by distinguishing centralised domination from coordination, and the anthropological objection because anarchists need only deny that hierarchy is the unique or best remedy. The fourth cannot: expertise, informal status and economic power return after the state disappears, and the tradition's own defenders concede that domination inside voluntary associations must be scrutinised. Marxism. The diagnosis is the most systematic of the three: exploitation arises through a formally free contract because workers lack independent access to the means of production and competition compels accumulation; alienation operates across product, activity, species-being and other persons; ideology naturalises historically specific relations; and the fetters mechanism explains why orders change. The remedy is the weakest of the three, because transitional states entrenched rather than withered, and the most developed transitional model contains no mechanism subordinating party to class - the substitutionism residual. Socialism. The diagnosis holds that productive capacities are socially inherited and cooperatively exercised, that private control of indispensable assets gives some persons power over others' life-chances, and that market outcomes do not track need, desert or equal freedom. The remedy is indeterminate rather than defeated: social control may be public, cooperative, guild, worker or mixed, and nationalisation is not automatically socialisation, so the family owes an account of accountable design that it has not settled. The common structure. In each case the remedy fails at the same point - it removes one form of standing power without demonstrating that it will not generate another. That is why "hidden authority", "substitutionism" and "bureaucratic domination" are three names for one problem. Qualification. The proposition should not be read as a dismissal. Every ideology contains a regulative picture of justified order, and feasibility must constrain normativity rather than replace it; an incomplete institutional answer is not an argument for the arrangements the diagnosis condemns. Verdict.

(b) Consider critically that gender discrimination is a rather man-made concept but not naturally endowed. [15 marks]

Model answer (254 words; practice model, not official): The claim, stated precisely. "Man-made" does not mean invented or unreal. It means that the inference from bodily difference to social role, authority and property is a social judgment, not an entailment. The five-step argument. Societies assign meanings and roles to bodily difference; those roles structure education, work, care, mobility, inheritance and authority; repeated expectation is internalised and begins to appear natural; institutional outcomes reinforce the original norm; therefore observed inequality cannot be inferred to be biologically necessary. The presupposition - social practice shapes preferences, capacities and self-conception - must be stated, since step three depends on it. Why the circle is self-confirming. The arrangement produces the very evidence later offered as its justification. "They do not lead" is an output of the arrangement, so an appeal to observed regularity settles nothing. First objection: biological difference. Some role differences reflect reproduction. Reply: biological facts do not determine who controls property, whose work is valued or who has authority; those conclusions require an independent justification never supplied. Second objection: constancy. If the pattern recurs across radically different societies, is that not evidence of nature? Reply: the content of the roles varies while the function - assigning immanence - recurs, so the constancy is institutional rather than biological. Two errors to refuse. Sex purely natural and gender purely artificial replaces one essence with two. "Constructed" read as unreal ignores that money, citizenship and caste are constructed and coercive alike. Verdict. The proposition is defensible once "man-made" is read as socially produced and institutionally sustained, not as arbitrary or easily revised.

(c) "The state may remove hindrances to freedom, but it may not define what freedom is for." Critically examine this claim with reference to the idealist and welfare-liberal accounts of the individual-state relation. [15 marks]

Model answer (250 words; practice model, not official): The claim's structure. The statement concedes an enabling role to the state and denies it a defining one. Its plausibility depends on whether that line can be held. Where it is strongest. T. H. Green's idealism supports it directly: the state is a means to the common good, and its proper work is to remove remediable hindrances to self-realisation while leaving moral agency with citizens. Welfare liberalism supports it too: formal rights are hollow where poverty, illness, ignorance or dependency makes choice unusable, so a social minimum and fair opportunity are justified without licensing

direction of life. On both accounts positive freedom is effective capacity, not an authorisation to prescribe ends. Where it comes under pressure. Hegel's account makes freedom concrete through participation in rational institutions, which suggests that institutions partly constitute what freedom is rather than merely clearing obstacles. And every hindrance-removal presupposes a judgment about which obstacles matter - a judgment that is not itself content-free. Objection and reply. Once the state defines the rational or higher self, coercion may be presented as liberation. The defensible reconstruction keeps enabling action rights-bound, decentralised where possible and open to public challenge; provision may still become paternalistic or dependency-producing, so the reply is a discipline rather than a guarantee. Verdict. The claim survives as a regulative principle rather than a sharp boundary: the state cannot avoid some conception of what hindrances are, but it can be held to justifying that conception publicly and to leaving the exercise of agency with the citizen.

Q4

(a) "Women is too internally divided a category to serve as the subject of a theory of gender justice." Critically discuss. [20 marks]

Model answer (333 words; practice model, not official): Position. The division is real and the conclusion does not follow; what follows is a change in method, not the abandonment of the category. The case for the claim. Intersectional analysis shows that gender is mediated by other structures. Caste operates through endogamy, labour, property, status and control of marriage and sexuality. Class operates through insecure work, unpaid labour and bargaining resources. Religion and community combine minority vulnerability with internal authority and personal-law disputes. Disability operates through dependency arrangements, accessibility and substituted decision-making. Sexuality and gender identity operate through compulsory heterosexuality, stigma and gender policing. bell hooks adds that dominant feminism can universalise privileged experience, so the centre misdescribes the margin. Why intersectionality is not arithmetic. It does not add independent disadvantages. It asks how institutions produce a distinct mechanism at their intersection - which is why a gender-only remedy can miss harms created through caste, class, community, disability or sexuality altogether. Why the conclusion still fails. Three replies. First, common claims to dignity and equality remain, and coalition is built on those rather than on uniformity of experience. Second, anti-discrimination practice already operates with provisionally stabilised categories, which is the strategic-essentialism position: a category may be used politically while its historical construction is conceded. Third, the objection proves too much - every social category is internally divided, so the argument would dissolve class, caste and citizenship alike. What does follow. A methodological requirement: trace the mechanism through the mediating axis rather than appending a sentence about compounded disadvantage. In India, anti-caste analysis is not an optional illustration; it changes the account of how the gender order is reproduced. The caste doctrine itself is owned elsewhere - name the mechanism and route it. The residue. Strategic essentialism is unstable: a category adopted for leverage hardens into a description and marginalises those it fits badly. The exchange is live and should be held open. Verdict. "Women" survives as a political and legal category kept internally diverse, historically constructed and open - a working criterion, not a settled resolution.

(b) Do you think that retributive theory of punishment is against human rights? Discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (297 words; practice model, not official): Position. It depends entirely on which retributivism is meant, and the distinction is not a hedge: maximising retributivism is in tension with rights, while limiting retributivism is the strongest ally rights possess inside penal theory. The doctrine. Kant holds that punishment must answer to the offender's culpable act and cannot be imposed merely to produce social utility, since treating a person only as an instrument of deterrence violates rational agency. Hegel holds that punishment negates the crime's wrongful claim and restores right while addressing the offender as a responsible agent rather than as a hazard. The maximising reading, and why it is exposed. If desert is read as a positive command to inflict suffering, the theory can license degradation, can be invoked to justify escalation and has no internal resource for limiting the form of punishment. On that reading the objection lands. The limiting reading, and what it forbids. Limiting retributivism claims two things only: no one may be punished without desert, and no penalty may exceed desert. Those are prohibitions, not commands, and they forbid precisely what rights-based objections most fear - conviction of the innocent for preventive gain, and escalation of severity beyond culpability. Retribution is not revenge. Four axes separate them: the agent is a public impartial authority rather than the injured party; the measure is proportionate desert rather than the intensity of grievance; there is a ceiling fixed by culpability rather than none; and like cases are treated alike rather than personally. Residue. Limiting retributivism does not close the general-justifying-aim gap: it explains why punishment may not exceed desert better than why the state must impose deserved suffering at all, and its cardinal ceiling must be anchored in dignity from outside desert. Verdict. A script that treats retributivism as one thing has answered neither.

(c) Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals. [15 marks]

Model answer (270 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Liberty and equality are indispensable political ideals whose weakness is identical in form: each is a family of demands rather than a single demand, and neither can rank its own members. Liberty evaluated. Its strength is the protection of a sphere of action and thought, without which a person acts only by another's permission. Berlin's distinction shows the family's internal division: freedom from interference against freedom to be one's own master. The objection to the negative pole is that it ignores poverty, illiteracy and dependency; the objection to the positive pole is that the real-self doctrine licenses coercion presented as liberation. The reply is that enabling conditions such as education expand freedom without dictating a life-plan. The residual problem is that no agreed test separates enablement from prescription. Equality evaluated. Its strength is the demand that persons be treated with equal concern, so arbitrary hierarchy must justify itself. But "equality of what?" divides the family - status, rights, opportunity, welfare, resources or capability. The objection that equality means levelling is met by the threshold reply: floors of decent capability and ceilings on avoidable deprivation, not identical holdings. The residual problem is that the threshold remains under-specified. The relation. At the level of basic liberties and equal civic standing the

two reinforce one another - free speech for all is at once a liberty and an equality. They compete beyond that threshold, where market advantage expands or equalisation reaches into choice. Verdict. Both ideals survive criticism and neither survives alone. The evaluation of each converges on the same conclusion: an ordering criterion is required, and supplying it is the work of justice.

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

(a) Discuss the nature of God as propounded in Nyaya philosophy. [10 marks]

Model answer (184 words; practice model, not official): Nyaya conceives Isvara within a pluralist realist ontology in which atoms, selves, space and time are also real. Isvara is one eternal, omniscient and incorporeal special self, never bound by karma, ignorance or bodily limitation; his agency is volitional rather than physical. His principal cosmological role is that of nimitta-karana, the intelligent efficient cause. Eternal atoms remain the material cause. At creation God initiates and coordinates atomic combinations; he sustains cosmic order and governs dissolution. Nyaya therefore accepts neither creation from nothing nor the Vedantic claim that God is also the material cause. Isvara also administers unseen moral potency (adrsta): karma supplies the basis of consequences, while God allots their fruits in accordance with desert, so human effort (purusakara) is preserved. Later Nyaya treats him as the authoritative author of the Veda. Critics argue that eternal atoms and karma together make God redundant. Nyaya replies that unconscious atoms and unconscious merit cannot intelligently order themselves. The view secures causal and moral governance, though the necessity of an infinite governor remains contestable - and the existence inferences belong to the proofs topic, not to this profile.

(b) "Non-theistic is not identical with atheistic." Examine the significance of this distinction for the possibility of religion without God. [10 marks]

Model answer (196 words; practice model, not official): The distinction decides the clause. Atheism denies that God exists; non-theism reports that a creator is absent from a tradition's diagnosis and path. The first is a claim about what exists, the second about what a path requires. Its significance is that non-theism leaves standing everything a religion needs. Theravada Buddhism permits cosmological gods while denying their creatorhood and salvific ultimacy; later Mahayana develops full devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas; Jainism venerates the perfected siddha. None of that would be available to a tradition committed to denying every deity and every sacred being. The distinction also redistributes the burden of proof. The non-theist need only show that a complete religious structure exists without a creator, which is a claim about actual traditions. The atheist must additionally defend a universal negative. The objection is that a creator assigned no role has effectively been denied. The reply is doctrinal: what Buddhism denies is creatorhood and final salvific power, not existence, and the surviving devotional practice is evidence that the narrower denial is the real one. Loose use of "atheistic" therefore concedes the theist's framing in the first line and makes a strong case sound like a weak one.

(c) Distinguish between the transcendence and the immanence of God, and explain why classical theism must assert both. [10 marks]

Model answer (178 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Transcendence and immanence are not two degrees of divine presence but two different relations, and classical theism asserts both because each alone destroys something the concept requires. Transcendence. Transcendence is ontological independence: God's being is not derived from, exhausted by or constrained by the world. It is not spatial remoteness, since a merely distant God would still be one item inside the same order of being. Immanence. Immanence is sustaining presence and activity: creaturely being depends on God at every moment, and secondary natural causes operate through that primary dependence rather than in competition with it. It is not physical inclusion, which would make God a part of the world. Why both. Pure transcendence yields the deist's absentee, for whom providence, grace and address become unintelligible. Pure immanence yields identity with nature, so no independent standard remains by which the world could be judged or redeemed. Ramanuja secures the same joint result by a different route: world and selves are God's real body, so the indwelling controller is genuinely present yet never reducible to the controlled. Verdict.

(d) Distinguish between alethic and soteriological religious pluralism, and state one consequence of the distinction. (Answer in about 150 words.) [10 marks]

Model answer (144 words; practice model, not official): Alethic pluralism concerns the truth of religious claims: it holds that several traditions state genuine truths about ultimate reality, because no finite formulation exhausts what it formulates. Soteriological pluralism concerns efficacy: it holds that several traditions really transform, liberate or save their adherents. The two are separable in both directions. One may hold that another tradition's doctrines are largely mistaken while conceding that its practice transforms; one may hold that its doctrines are substantially true while denying that its path is efficacious for salvation. The consequence is decisive for the standard argument. Hick's soteriological criterion - transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness - assesses traditions for authenticity and, by his own statement, does not render contradictory doctrines jointly true. A script that treats the criterion as settling the truth question has conceded the relativism charge without argument, since it has answered an alethic objection with soteriological evidence.

(e) Elucidate the personalistic and impersonalistic aspects of God. [10 marks]

Model answer (167 words; practice model, not official): The personalistic aspect conceives God as possessing intellect, will, purpose and the capacity for relation. Classical theism's creator and Ramanuja's Saguna Brahman know, govern, love and respond. This makes prayer, revelation, moral command, grace and providence intelligible. Personality, however, is predicated analogically; it does not imply a finite body or changing human psychology. The impersonalistic aspect conceives ultimate reality as beyond person-like

volition. Spinoza's God is the one infinite substance whose modes follow necessarily, not a deity choosing among worlds. Sankara's Nirguna Brahman transcends limiting predicates; Saguna Ishvara and devotion are valid empirically, while ultimate realization sublates subject-object duality. Personalism risks anthropomorphism and faces the problem of reconciling immutable perfection with response and worldly evil. Impersonalism protects infinity, unity and necessity, but weakens reciprocal worship, providence and moral address. The alternatives need not be mechanically combined. Advaita orders them as empirical and ultimate; Visishtadvaita rejects this hierarchy and makes divine personality supreme. Thus the issue is whether ultimacy is best understood as perfect agency or transpersonal ground.

Q6

(a) Is the ontological proof for the existence of God by St. Anselm logical? Discuss. [20 marks]

Model answer (379 words; practice model, not official): Whether Anselm's proof is "logical" must be split into two questions: is it valid, and is its key premise legitimate? Anselm's Proslogion 2 argument is a reductio. Suppose that than which nothing greater can be conceived exists in the understanding alone. Existing in reality is greater than existing in the understanding alone. Then a greater than the greatest conceivable could be conceived - a contradiction. Therefore it exists in reality. Formally this is impeccable: given the definition and the comparative premise, the conclusion follows. Proslogion 3 strengthens it: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can, so God exists necessarily; since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. The difficulty is not the inference but the comparative premise. Gaunilo, in *In Behalf of the Fool*, constructs a parallel for the most perfect conceivable island; if the form is valid, it manufactures islands. Anselm replies that only God is defined as having eternal and independent existence, whereas an island - a piece of land surrounded by water - is by definition contingent and can without contradiction be thought not to exist. The reply succeeds for the second form, but it transfers the burden: it must now be shown that maximal greatness is a coherent notion with an intrinsic maximum, whereas island-perfections plainly are not. Kant supplies the decisive diagnosis. Existence is not a real predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones. If so, "existing in reality is greater" is not a legitimate comparison of concepts at all, and the argument is valid only in the trivial sense that it correctly draws out what was illicitly built in. Modern quantificational analysis reinforces this by treating existence as second-order. Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and Plantinga preserve necessary existence and are formally valid in S5; but their possibility premise - that a maximally great being is possible - is precisely what is disputed, and a symmetrical possibility-of-non-existence yields the opposite conclusion. Verdict: Anselm's proof is logically well-formed but not logically compelling. It is valid in form, question-begging in premise, and at best establishes a conditional: if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily.

(b) Critically examine the claim that the divine attributes form a single package whose members constrain one another. [15 marks]

Model answer (252 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The attributes are a package rather than a list: each is stated in a way that limits how the others may be stated, and the standard defences work by specifying terms rather than by adding new ones. Constraint one - power and possibility. Omnipotence must be restricted to the absolutely possible, since a contradictory description names no object of power (Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I q.25 a.3). The restriction protects goodness too, because impeccability then counts as a perfection rather than a deficiency of power. Constraint two - knowledge and freedom. Exhaustive foreknowledge plus the fixity of the past threatens libertarian alternatives. The four standard exits - timeless eternity, soft facts about the past, middle knowledge (*scientia media*), and open theism - each pay a different price, from contested metaphysics to the grounding objection to an amended omniscience. Constraint three - changelessness and personality. Knowledge, love and response look personal only if God stands in real changing relations, yet changelessness denies intrinsic change. The distinction between intrinsic change and new relations or effects is the standard repair, and it remains disputed. The systemic point. Non-composition tightens the package further: if the attributes are one reality diversely signified, no attribute can be traded off against another, which is why modal collapse and the property objection are so damaging. Verdict. The claim survives. Each attribute is coherent once specified, but every specification narrows what the religious believer originally wanted to assert - and the cumulative narrowing, not any single paradox, is the strongest objection to the classical package.

(c) Does the diversity of mystical experience weaken its claim to disclose an objective transcendent reality? Critically examine. [15 marks]

Model answer (212 words; practice model, not official): Mystical experience is commonly described as noetic, ineffable, transient and passive, but its evidential force is disputed because traditions report different objects: a personal God, non-dual Brahman, emptiness or an impersonal sacred order. The diversity objection argues that mutually incompatible interpretations cannot all be veridical descriptions of one transcendent reality. Naturalistic explanations from psychology and neuroscience further show that unusual states can arise through meditation, deprivation, illness or suggestion. These objections defeat any simple inference from intensity to truth. They do not, however, make the experience worthless. William James treats its fruits in transformed conduct as relevant, though moral fruit cannot establish the metaphysics that produced it. William Alston compares mystical perception with socially established doxastic practices, but the plurality of rival practices weakens that analogy. John Hick responds by distinguishing an ineffable Real from culturally shaped phenomenal appearances; critics reply that this theory redescribes traditions from outside and risks unfalsifiability. The balanced verdict is evidentially modest: mystical experience may provide *prima facie* personal justification and important phenomenological data, but public proof requires independent coherence, intersubjective testing and an explanation of religious diversity. Its public weight should therefore rise when independent reports converge, the experience produces stable epistemic and moral fruits, and alternative causal explanations have been seriously examined rather than ignored.

Q7

(a) "Every Indian conception of liberation is determined by its account of bondage." Examine this thesis across the major schools, and state what follows for the means of liberation. [20 marks]

Model answer (321 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The terminus is fixed by the diagnosis. Tell me what a school takes bondage to be, and its conception of release - and its permitted means - follow. School by school. Advaita: bondage is ignorance (avidya), so release is the removal of an error, individuality is sublated, and only knowledge can remove it; liberation while living (jivanmukti) is possible because nothing must be acquired, the body continuing on already-fructifying karma. Visistadvaita: bondage is karma and dependence, so release is an attained relation - communion and service - reached by knowledge, devotion (dhruvanasmṛti) and self-surrender (prapatti), with grace decisive. Nyaya-Vaisesika: bondage is the conjunction that generates pain, traced back to false knowledge, so release is the cessation of pain and of the qualities sustaining experience, reached by true knowledge of the categories. Samkhya-Yoga: bondage is non-discrimination (aviveka), not a real bond, so release is discriminative discernment (viveka-khyati) and the terminus is contentless aloneness; karikas 62-63 add that strictly no puruṣa was ever bound. Jainism: bondage is quasi-material karmic matter attracted by passion, so release requires stoppage (samvara) and shedding (nirjara) - an ethics of restraint and austerity rather than of knowledge alone. Buddhism: bondage is craving and ignorance, so release is their extinguishing, reached by the path, with no self to be freed. What follows for the means. The production versus removal fork governs everything: if release is a result to be produced, action can produce it (Mimamsa); if it is the removal of an error, only knowledge removes it (Samkhya); if it is an attained relation, devotion and grace are intelligible as direct means (Ramanuja). Action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes. Qualification. The thesis is strong but not absolute: Jainism's material diagnosis makes practice, not cognition, the primary means, showing that the diagnosis fixes the kind of means as much as the terminus. Conclusion. Conceptions of liberation are not free-standing ideals; they are the exact inverse of each school's account of what has gone wrong.

(b) Do analogy and symbol clarify religious language, or merely protect it from verification? Critically examine. [15 marks]

Model answer (213 words; practice model, not official): Literal univocal language makes God one object among others, while wholly equivocal language prevents any intelligible claim. Aquinas' doctrine of analogy seeks a middle path: predicates such as good apply to creatures and God in related but unequal ways because created perfections participate in their source. Tillich similarly treats religious symbols as participating in the reality they disclose and opening levels of experience inaccessible to technical description. These accounts explain why religious discourse can be meaningful without being a scientific report. The verification objection remains serious. If every apparent counter-instance is redescribed symbolically, claims risk dying by a thousand qualifications, as Flew argues. Braithwaite's moral interpretation preserves use but may surrender truth, while Wittgensteinian language-games can be misread as immunising a practice from external criticism. Analogy and symbol are therefore legitimate semantic devices, not automatic exemptions from evidence. Their claims must retain identifiable implications, cohere with the tradition's other beliefs and remain open to moral and experiential challenge. A claimant should specify what the analogy rules out, how competing symbols are compared, and what would count as misuse. Otherwise semantic humility becomes evidential immunity. Properly disciplined, symbolic language expands reference while leaving claims available for rational criticism. Its success depends on accountable interpretation rather than an unrestricted retreat from ordinary standards of assertion.

(c) Examine the claim that personal identity, rather than immortality, is the real philosophical issue in the survival debate. Illustrate with both Western and Indian material. [15 marks]

Model answer (263 words; practice model, not official): The claim. Whether something survives is less contested than what would make the survivor me. Immortality answers a question about duration; identity answers a question about sameness, and the second is prior. The criteria. Four rivals: bodily continuity, psychological or memory continuity, soul-substance, and causal continuity. The first two tell us how identity is recognised; the last two propose what constitutes it. Memory cannot define identity, since it presupposes it and is fallible and branchable. Western illustration. Resurrection faces the gap problem and the re-assembly objection. Aquinas secures continuity by treating the rational soul as the form of the body; van Inwagen has God preserve the body or a core of it; Hick's replica theory holds that a unique psychophysical duplicate with continuous memory and character, appearing in another space, is the same person for every purpose that matters. The duplication objection answers that if God can make one replica he can make two, and identity is one-to-one - so the criterion tracks similarity. Indian illustration. Vedanta and Nyaya answer with a substance; Jainism with an eternal individual soul; Samkhya distinctively denies that the witness migrates at all (Samkhya-karika 62-63); and Buddhism replaces the owner with a causal stream, defending responsibility by causal descent - "neither the same nor wholly other". The memory objection to rebirth is the mirror-image of the duplication objection to resurrection. Assessment. Both traditions can secure duration and struggle to secure sameness, which is precisely the claim under examination. Conclusion. Immortality is the headline; identity is the argument - and every serious position in this clause is finally a choice of continuity-bearer.

Q8

(a) Critically examine the arguments of Nyaya for the existence of God. [20 marks]

Model answer (374 words; practice model, not official): Nyaya offers a rational, inferential theism. Isvara is an eternal, omniscient special self, the first efficient cause - a demiurgus or builder of the ordered universe - not its material cause; He is also preserver and destroyer, which distinguishes Nyaya theism from deism. Karyat - the causal argument. All composite objects of the world are effects, since they are made of parts (savayava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avantara-mahattva); space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities, and atoms and manas as simple infinitesimals. Material causes alone cannot attain the order, direction

and co-ordination that produce such effects. The intelligent cause must therefore have direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it - and must be omniscient, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms. Ayojanat - inert atoms cannot combine purposively of themselves. Dhrtiyadeh - the world's support, maintenance and dissolution require governance. Padat / aptapramanya - the Veda's authority derives from an omniscient author, as a science's authority derives from its founder; the jiva cannot be that author, since supramundane realities exceed ordinary cognition. Sruteh - scripture directly testifies to God. Finally, the argument from adrsta: differences of lot require causes; karma supplies them; but the time-gap requires a persisting stock of merit and demerit; and adrsta, being unintelligent, cannot allot precisely the joy and sorrow deserved, while individual selves neither know nor control it. Hence God is karmaphaladata. Critically: the circularity charge against the last two arguments is answered by distinguishing the order of existence (God creates the Veda) from the order of knowledge (the Veda discloses God); the bodiless-agent objection is met by a dilemma. But the deeper objections stand. Mimamsa holds the Veda apauruseya and apurva self-maturing, which dissolves two arguments at once. Buddhism and Jainism hold that conditions and material karma suffice. Carvaka denies inference's reach. Sankara presses a dilemma on whether atoms are active or inactive, and treats Nyaya's God as merely saguna. C. D. Sharma's redundancy objection is sharpest: this God is "reduced to the status of a supervisor", His hands and feet "chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the Adrsta". Verdict: the arguments are individually inconclusive but cumulatively serious, in Udayana's manner.

(b) Present an exposition of ontological proof for the existence of God along with its criticism. [15 marks]

Model answer (267 words; practice model, not official): Exposition (10). The ontological proof is the sole classical a priori argument: it moves from the concept of God to God's existence without any empirical premise. Anselm defines God as "that than which nothing greater can be conceived", where "greater" means more perfect - and deliberately not as "the most perfect being that there is", which would guarantee nothing. In Proslogion 2 he argues by reductio: even the fool who denies God understands the concept; but if this being existed in the understanding alone, we could conceive a greater - the same being existing in reality as well - which contradicts the definition; therefore it exists in reality. In Proslogion 3 he strengthens the conclusion: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; and since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. God therefore exists necessarily, by aseity. Descartes reformulates it in Meditations V: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle, or a valley to a mountain; a perfect being lacking existence would lack a perfection. Criticism (5). Gaunilo, in In Behalf of the Fool, parodies the form with the most perfect conceivable island; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary existence, an island being by definition contingent - but the reply then requires that maximal greatness be coherent. Kant's objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate; a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. Modal repairs preserve validity but relocate the burden onto an unestablished possibility premise.

(c) What proofs do Nyaya philosophers offer for the existence of God? Discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (277 words; practice model, not official): Nyaya offers not one proof but an array - the tradition claims as many as ten, though enumerations vary across texts and summaries, so an answer should present the principal ones and say so. Karyat, the causal argument, is central. All composite objects - mountains, seas, sun and moon - are effects, since they are made of parts (savayava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avantara-mahattva). Space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities; atoms and manas as simple infinitesimals. Material causes cannot by themselves attain the order and co-ordination required to produce such effects, so an intelligent maker is needed, possessing direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it. He must be omniscient, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms. Ayojanat: inert atoms require purposive combination. Dhrtiyadeh: the world's support, maintenance and destruction imply governance. Padat / aptapramanya: the Veda's authority presupposes an omniscient trustworthy author, since no jiva can know supramundane realities. Sruteh: scripture testifies directly. The argument from adrsta completes the set: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot itself allot the precise joy and sorrow deserved, nor do selves know or control it; hence God is karmaphaladata, the impartial dispenser. Throughout, Isvara is the efficient, not material, cause: atoms are eternal, and God orders rather than produces them; He also preserves and destroys, which makes Nyaya theistic rather than deistic. Discussion: the proofs are mutually reinforcing in Udayana's cumulative manner, but each is contested - Mimamsa by apauruseya and apurva, Buddhism and Jainism by karmic sufficiency, Carvaka by restricting pramanas. They establish a probable cosmic administrator rather than a demonstrated absolute.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS